

**Mapping the Journey:
Understanding the Role of Habitus and
Capitals in Chinese International
Students' Cultural Fit**

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Thankfully,

The Shelter of Education Studies Gifts Me Chance to Believe.

Thankfully,

the Realm of Social Science Affords Aspiration Space to Breathe.

Abstract

This article explores the cultural fit challenges Chinese international undergraduate students from middle-class families in Shanghai face as they transition into Western academic environments. These students are often from resource-rich families and have a parallel experience with international education from an early age. Employing Pierre Bourdieu's theoretical frameworks of capital and habitus, this study presents how habitus and informational capital contribute to achieving cultural fit. Through in-depth interviews with eight Chinese students, the research reveals that students who achieve better fit-in usually have greater adaptability and the ability to maximize existing resources and strengths in forming sustainable information-gathering methods in a new environment.

1 Introduction

According to UNESCO's 2019 report, 145,779 Chinese students were pursuing secondary and higher education in the UK, accounting for 24% of the total international student population. Between 2010 and 2017, the number of Chinese students in the UK grew at an average annual rate of 9% (UK Council for International Student Affairs, 2017). Students who study abroad often come from families with substantial resources and privileges (Zhang and Tang, 2021), enabling them to be geographically mobile. However, such high levels of mobility often come with feelings of unease and the "hidden injuries" of being caught between two worlds, as described by Sennett and Cobb (1972). Numerous studies have confirmed that international students, lacking the benefits of years of gradual socialization available to most indigenous members of the host culture, see the advantages of citizenship in their home countries replaced by a new minority status (Brown, 2007; Newsome & Cooper, 2016). Scholars have also identified and explained obstacles in the transition experience, such as language barriers, interpersonal problems, homesickness, and cultural shock (Newsome and Cooper, 2016; Sovic, 2009; Yu & Moskal, 2018).

Recognizing international students' complex and intersectional diversity (Ovie & Barrantes, 2019), this article mainly focuses on the cohort of undergraduates from Shanghai, China. As articulated by Zhang and Tang (2021), these undergraduates who can afford years of international tuition fees typically hail from upper-and middle-class families that avail them of rich cultural and educational resources along with the privilege of early exposure to international education. By focusing on this relatively advantaged group among Chinese international students, this essay accentuates the role of exclusive educational resources and

avoids generalizing international students as one homogenized group. These resources include linguistic competence, proactive opportunity-seeking skills, rapid cultural adaptation, and networking skills, all of which assume critical significance in transnational educational settings (Munk, 2009).

Shanghai, as the financial hub in the global sphere and a culturally rich city (Long Finance, 2020; Shanghai Municipal Statistics Bureau, 2020), magnified the privilege of these students. Besides, with plenty of international schools and quite a hefty and diverse expatriate community culture, this city enables youth to have a global lens and, accordingly, have many considerable advantages abroad. Such resources and opportunities allow them to be valued as international-minded individuals in a globalizing world (Cebolla-Boado et al., 2018).

This study focuses on students of a privileged cohort within the general international student community—both because of their socio-economic status and cultural background. The latter aspect becomes especially pertinent in diversified educational settings like the one at University College London (UCL), known for its outstanding diversity and high proportion of international students. These privileged backgrounds provide a rich data source for research exploring the more profound issues Chinese international students face with cultural fit in the UK.

To investigate the impact of exclusive information that is usually accessible to a selected segment of the population, this study delves into the experiences of "first-in-family" (FiF) university students, defined as those who are the first person coming to the UK to pursue undergraduate education (Spiegler & Bednarek, 2013). The absence of prior family experience in higher education and limited access to informational capital led to significant obstacles during their study abroad, entailing a complex process marked by substantial emotional and

social adjustments (Lessky, Nairz-Wirth, & Feldmann, 2021; O'Shea, 2019). This investigation seeks to illuminate the challenges encountered by students handling physical and cultural frontiers, devoid of direct guidance or institutional "insider" knowledge from close family members (Crozier et al., 2008).

This research involved interviews with eight Chinese international students about their undergraduate experiences at a university in the UK. Following a wealth of literature in the discourse of international education, this essay employs a Bourdieu-inspired analytical framework. By utilizing the derived concepts of informational capital and cleft habitus, this study qualitatively investigates the transition experiences of international students, emphasising cultural integration and the influence of privilege. These concepts are typically employed to discuss working-class students' internal struggles and practical transformations within elite educational environments (Ivemark & Ambrose, 2023). Elite education is tailored for a small, influential segment of the population (Doughty, 2020), with privileged families often opting for selective, exclusive educational paths that mirror social origins (Sullivan et al., 2016; Grodsky, 2007). This education fosters skill development, attaining prestigious degrees, and building essential networks like the "old school tie" (Sullivan et al., 2016, p.29). These factors help students maintain higher status positions in elite universities and professions, ultimately reproducing social status (Shen, 2023). In the context of international students, internal struggles also exist since they encounter significant cultural disparities.

2 Literature Review

This section starts by reviewing relevant literature on the study abroad experiences of Chinese international students. Acknowledging the impact of elite education, this study involves the concepts from Pierre Bourdieu's seminal works as the theoretical framework. Bourdieu's insights contribute significantly to analyzing and comprehending how education persistently contributes to the reproduction of social status (Lamont & Lareau, 1988).

2.1 Empirical Context

"Cultural fit" is an inseparable topic in the discourse of overseas study (e.g., Newsome and Cooper, 2016). As habitus adapts to social spaces or applies to the new cultural environment, a "cultural fit" may occur, explaining the mechanisms of social reproduction within the fields where habitus operates (Bourdieu, 1990b; Bourdieu & Passeron, 1977). The sense of dislocation that arises when individuals face unfamiliar cultures and struggle to adapt to new social contexts can be termed cultural shock (Newsome & Cooper, 2016). People sometimes withdraw from these environments, a response described by Friebertshäuser (1992) as "fleeing from the field". For international students, particularly Chinese students in the UK, the significant cultural disparities between China and the UK may lead to substantial cultural shock (Zhang, 2023).

Many scholars have noted that for international students, studying abroad is pursuing experiences in the host country rather than abandoning the old culture (Newsome & Cooper, 2016). However, maintaining cultural heritage and exposure to new cultures in new settings

could happen simultaneously. In this context, seeking broader interactions with the host society may promote the establishment of intercultural contact (Yu & Moskal, 2018). Building social networks in university significantly enhances students' educational experiences and learning outcomes. According to Cassidy (2004), these networks often evolve into a vital source of social support, supplanting family and previous friendships and fostering a strong sense of community and belonging among students.

Similarly, research by Ramsay, Jones, and Barker (2006) highlights that, particularly for first-year studying abroad students, friends become the primary source of emotional, practical, and social support and an essential source of information. When interaction occurs between individuals from different cultures, it not only enhances the overall educational experience (Dunne, 2013) but also increases developmental possibilities for students (Gurin et al., 2002). This interaction establishes a cyclical relationship where motivated and capable students gain more opportunities, which fosters confidence for further explorations.

Peer relationships generally "provide stability and a secure source of information about studying and the university" (Lessky, Nairz-Wirth & Feldmann, 2021, p.35). For international students, belonging to the vast community of international students can be significantly supportive when they first arrive (Zhang, 2023). Students from the same country tend to bond more tightly when abroad. However, the inability to move out of the comfort zones may deprive the preconditions for developing cross-cultural social networks that facilitate cultural fit (Yu & Moskal, 2018). According to Spencer-Oatey et al. (2017), while 92% of students reported satisfactory interactions with fellow compatriots, these figures dropped to 60% and 78% for interactions with host country nationals and people from other countries, respectively.

Establishing cross-cultural friendships faces additional challenges due to differences in language, culture, values, interests, and plans (Zhang, 2023), which are thought to be interrelated with well-being as they interact within an ecosystem (Elliot, Reid & Baumfield, 2015). A significant number of students are dissatisfied with being unable to integrate and having to meet their social and adaptation needs through compatriot communities (Chen & Ross, 2015). Their attitudes towards the "Chinese circle," a result of racial clustering, are ambivalent; they appreciate the comfort it provides yet lament its restriction on forming cross-cultural friendships (Holliman et al., 2023). On the contrary, some scholars find that students view their social relations holistically, assessing whether social networks' overall quantity and quality provide adequate support (Zhang, 2023). Hence, they don't mind if they make local friends or not.

Extensive literature emphasizes the importance of English language proficiency for international students' academic success and social adjustment (Andrade, 2006; Sherry, Thomas & Chui, 2010). Although many students pass language exams, they often struggle with effective communication, leading to loneliness, anxiety, and reduced confidence, particularly in conversations with native speakers (Kim, 2020; Sovic, 2009). Additionally, the speech style of middle-class students tends to receive more social approval, posing a further challenge for international students whose test preparation does not typically include these skills (Aries & Seider, 2005).

2.2 Theoretical Framework

Discussions deploying concepts in Bourdieu's work (1977) typically proceed with the understanding that entering any social field requires adherence to its specific regulative

principles, often referred to as the "rules of the game" (Edgerton & Roberts, 2014)—this study mainly draws on the notions of informational capital and cleft habitus.

2.2.1 Capitals and Informational Capitals

In Bourdieu's conceptual framework (1984, 1986), three forms of capital are crucial in determining one's position within the social structure. Firstly, economic capital is directly and immediately convertible into money and is seen as a primary goal within societal structures (Bourdieu, 1986; O'Shea & Richardson, 1987). Secondly, social capital, deeply rooted in relationships and encompasses valuable assets acquired through institutionalized relationships characterized by stability and predictability, facilitates reciprocity among network members (Field, 2016; Oyefuga and Shakeshaft, 2021). As these relationships are instrumental for individuals in gathering information, this social capital is crucial for providing an insightful perspective (Munk, 2009; Santos and Costa, 2015). Finally, cultural capital is associated with privileged habitus and dispositions (Ostrower, 1998; Reay, 2017). Within the discourse of education, elite education is generally regarded as a stepping-stone to acquiring cultural capital, which aims at achieving social advancement or perpetuating social reproduction (Ponzini, 2020). It encapsulates competencies and immaterial knowledge, such as linguistic abilities, appropriate attire, behaviour in specific circumstances, and strategies to procure job opportunities (Aries & Seider, 2005). Besides, Bourdieu extensively discussed symbolic capital, a significant source of power and social prestige (Ponzini, 2020), where "becoming international" exemplified a highly coveted form of symbolic capital (Basaran & Olsson, 2017). Yosso (2005) extended Bourdieu's limited categorization of capital in the discourse of broader social equity, advocating for a more comprehensive framework particularly relevant to the intercultural situation of underrepresented populations in a particular context (Nuñez, 2009).

When discussing social capital's impact on academic achievement, Oyefuga and Shakeshaft (2021, p.165) further broadened the definition of capital, suggesting it encompasses "anything and everything."

Amidst these theoretical developments, informational capital was introduced, recognized by scholars like Edgerton and Roberts (2014) and Munk (2009) for its ability to morph into economic and social capital while signalling social positioning by encompassing aspects of cultural and symbolic capital (Edgerton & Roberts, 2014; Munk, 2009). In the educational sector, this form of capital provides information about the "rules of the game" in educational institutions, such as available learning opportunities (Santos and Costa, 2015). Munk (2009) perceived informational capital as academic capital that is essential for building knowledge about educational and career options and aiding exploration in educational systems and professional organizations (St, Hu and Fisher, 2010). In elite institutions, vital information not readily available through official channels, alongside many practical details, is divided into "practical knowledge of study-related processes" and "understanding and anticipation of study-related logistics" (Lessky, Nairz-Wirth and Feldmann, 2021, p.29). The former includes exclusive information from peer networks, while the latter comprises a broader range of knowledge essential for understanding the system and finding one's path upon entering university. According to Lareau and Horvat (1999), the value of capital is dependent upon the social setting in which an individual is situated. However, as Winkler and Sriram (2015) argued, this elite's mechanism globally rewards privileged communities. Even though the setting may vary, the value is universally built upon the norms belonging to the dominant group in the global society, who are always valued and rewarded (Stanton-Salazar, 1997).

In the international student discourse, Spencer-Oatey et al. (2017) have demonstrated that increased social networking accompanies more interaction with local students and staff.

Eventually, this will result in a favourable outcome for the overall cultural fit. Facing cultural shock, the decision of international students to withdraw or actively achieve better fit-in largely depends on their ability to establish relationships with key figures in the new environment and to obtain critical institutional resources and opportunities (Stanton-Salazar, 1997). Building on Stanton-Salazar's (1997) observation that norms associated with the dominant social group are globally recognized and rewarded, Winkler and Sriram (2015) highlight the presence of a universal mechanism within global higher education systems. This mechanism systematically perpetuates elites' advantages by institutionally favouring the activation of social and cultural capital, which is held mainly by privileged groups. In essence, students with informational capital not only acquire exclusive information about the shared mechanism but also recognize that information's value lies in how its owner utilizes it (Gigler, 2011) and the means to gather it. In other words, they possess a habitus that allows their capital and mobility to flow together (Sassen, 2019). This study employs informational capital as a theoretical framework to illustrate the "rules of the game" when studying abroad.

2.2.2 Habitus and Cleft Habitus

The concepts of habitus and cleft habitus are employed to explore the internal conflict that international student encounter due to the differences between their pre-transition and post-transition environments. Habitus is a set of durable and transposable dispositions that individuals acquire through family upbringing and their position in the social structure (Bourdieu, 2002; Edgerton and Roberts, 2014). It acts as an internalized interpretive framework, often referred to by Bourdieu as “socialized subjectivity,” which shapes how individuals perceive the social world and their prospects within it. As a schema or a structure of perception, conception and action, habitus is deeply rooted in one's socialization within the family

(Bourdieu, 2002). Thereby, habitus internalizes owners' social position into tastes and worldviews and affects their position in society (Lee & Kramer, 2012). It is important to note that while habitus is enduring, it is also susceptible to change as a fluid disposition (Edgerton & Roberts, 2014). Although associated with the societal class position, habitus is fluid and adaptable, continuously reinforcing or transforming in response to new experiences (Bourdieu, 1977, 1990a; Lamont & Lareau, 1988). In the context of higher education, Lee and Kramer (2012) reaffirmed habitus' capacity to evolve in response to novel contexts and individual experiences during university.

When individuals experience an internal conflict because their ingrained behaviours and thoughts no longer align with their society, their habitus may alter. The notion of cleft habitus is frequently employed to elucidate the topic of social mobility (Ivemark & Ambrose, 2023; Ingram & Abrahams, 2015; Martin & Harrison, 2022). It is commonly exemplified by working-class students' elite university experience when facing inherent clashes (Lubrano, 2005). Holding two habitus simultaneously typifies cleft habitus (Bourdieu, 2006, 2008). Ivemark and Ambrose's (2023) empirical research highlights subjects acquiring new dispositions while being continuously structured by inherited dispositions, leading to intense internal conflicts and self-reflection. International students' entry into new environments frequently results in dissatisfaction and maladjustment with its "rules of the game," which continues to manifest complex internal struggles, showing the occurrence of cleft habitus.

However, the experience of cleft habitus might also foster new capital and habitus for international students. "Becoming international" is regarded by Basaran and Olsson (2017) as a symbolic capital. Students accustomed to navigating unfamiliar "rules of the game" possess adaptability as a form of cultural capital (Lareau & Weininger, 2003), benefiting students from a more flexible capital structure (Edgerton & Roberts, 2014). In this case, "becoming

international" is not only a mode of thinking that integrates transnational in-between positions (Wang, 2022) but also a habitus. This habitus enables international students to recontextualize their capitals and foster a dynamic interplay in their unique fluid situations (Hannerz, 1990; Peng, 2015). Considering Wang's (2022) call for education policymakers to wisely recognize the powerful force behind international students' transnational intermediary identities, it is essential to acknowledge both dimensions— "becoming international" as both an identity naturally acquired after studying abroad and as a habitus cultivated during the experience.

Chinese international students are becoming an increasingly significant group in Western universities, and their situation is garnering growing attention. Ongoing discussions iterate various factors such as racism, feelings of hostility and alienation, environments with a high density of international students, inherent cultural differences, and preconceptions about student life abroad (Holliman et al., 2023; Newsome and Cooper, 2016; Peacock & Harrison, 2008). Extensive studies highlight the specificity, complexity, and diversity of international students' cultural fit situations (Yu and Moskal, 2018). However, as Newsome and Cooper (2016) suggested, we need to understand the role of structural impacts in educational discourse and avoid an overly narrow focus on specific characteristics or concerns like language or social life. With the notion of "the rules of the game," this study explores how the interplay of pre-transition habitus and informational capital guides individuals in understanding, interpreting, and applying the rules to their post-transition setting.

3 Research Questions

RQ1: How do Chinese international students achieve a cultural fit when they come to study in the UK?

RQ2: What roles do habitus and informational capital play in achieving cultural fit for Chinese international students?

4 Methodology

4.1 Research Design

This qualitative investigation follows the constructivist paradigm. Since the goal was to gain an in-depth understanding of Chinese students' cross-cultural experiences (Bhattacharya, 2017), I decided to use a qualitative method to learn the subjective realm of meaning-making, aiming to demonstrate the deeper reasons behind the phenomena (Cheek & Schutt, 2012). I embraced the perspective that human behaviour and action are rooted in the meanings individuals ascribe to people and things and how these meanings are interpreted and conveyed through language (Charmaz, 2019). This epistemological view, advocating that knowledge and meaning emerge from the interplay of experiences and ideas, especially in the discourse of educational research, theory, and policy (Duffy, 2006), suits the exploratory nature of the research (Bogdan & Biklen, 1998). My study builds on the Bourdieusian tradition, in which theory-building and empirical research are seen not as separate endeavours but interconnected processes (Lessky, Nairz-Wirth and Feldmann, 2021). Overall, the personal experiences narrated by different participants and the various perceptions that arise during the transition process can be assembled like a puzzle, allowing me as a researcher to interpret or discover the notion of a shared reality (Charmaz, 2019) of individuals within this context.

4.2 Sampling and Participants

The eight participants were recruited through a non-probability and snowball sampling within UCL (for more details, see Table 1). Based on my understanding of the people around me, such an approach could quickly help me filter out individuals who simultaneously meet three criteria: having been educated in Shanghai before coming to London, studying for an undergraduate degree at UCL, and having core family members who have not received higher education in the UK.

Table 1 Participant Profile

	Yutong	Wenyi	Stephanie	Haocheng	Yifan	Mengke	Xiao
Gender	Female	Female	Female	Male	Female	Female	Male
Program	Geography	Education Studies	Law	Mathematics	Education Studies	Education Studies	Electronic and Electrical Engineering
Grade	3	3	3	3	3	Graduated	2
Nationality	Chinese	Chinese	American	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese
Hometown	Jiangsu	Zhejiang	Hangkong/Shanghai	Shanghai	Shanghai	Zhejiang	Shanghai
Where to get Alevel score	Shanghai	Shanghai	Shanghai	Shanghai	Shanghai	Shanghai	Shanghai
School Attended	Large Scale A-level school	Small Scale A-level school	Private International School	High Ranking Public school+ Alevel tutoring	Public Foreign Language School	Public school in Zhejiang+ Alevel tutoring center	Public school in Shanghai+ Large Scale Alevel school
Language Level(Mandarin)	Native	Native	Proficient	Native	Native	Native	Native
Language Level(English)	Fluent	Fluent	Native	Fluent	Proficient	Fluent	Fluent

4.3 Data Collection

The interview was chosen to capture the evolving social experiences of students, leveraging the qualitative analysis's potential for generating new theories and unexpected findings (Yin, 2016). Existing studies exploring international students' cultural and social experiences usually adopt interviews (e.g. Newsome and Cooper, 2016; Wang, 2022; Zhang, 2023). Semi-structured interview, as a common data collection technique in qualitative studies, offer flexibility through follow-up questions (DiCicco-Bloom & Crabtree, 2006; Kallio et al., 2016). This method allows questions to be adapted based on participant responses and provides space

for participants to express themselves (Cohen & Crabtree, 2006). As Sovic (2009) notes, meaningful understanding of a specific group's perspectives requires recognizing the different characteristics exhibited by individuals.

I posted a brief description of my research on social platforms. After casually chatting with interested individuals, I selected eight participants. Given the differences in their educational background details, it is very likely to offer rich and varied insights into the study, thus enhancing the informational richness of the discussion (Creswell, 2013). Before the interviews, I sent an information sheet and an ethics form to the participant via email, where I also inquired about their preferred language for expressing thoughts. All but one respondent, who identified English as her first language, chose Mandarin for the interviews. Conducting interviews in their first language enhanced the accuracy of oral expression and fostered greater trust. An interview guide (see Appendix 4) covering key research topics, developed based on preliminary research in the field (Taylor, 2005; Wengraf, 2001), directed the discussions.

I conducted eight semi-structured interviews between March 11 and March 23, 2024, each lasting 30 to 45 minutes. I utilized Zoom as the interview platform to increase efficiency. The interviews were recorded, transcriptions were made using Zoom's transcription feature for English and Xunfei software for Mandarin, facilitating analysis (Cohen & Crabtree, 2006). Transcriptions were completed within six hours post-interview, with Mandarin transcripts roughly translated into English via DeepL, followed by manual verification and my adjustments for accuracy.

4.4 Data Analysis

In line with a constructivist paradigm, this study used Braun and Clarke's (2006) thematic analysis to examine interview data, involving six steps: familiarization with the data, generating initial codes, searching for themes, reviewing themes, defining and renaming themes, and producing the report. This comprehensive process, which incorporates both a priori and posterior coding, systematically categorizes themes into broader themes while offering flexibility, making it suitable for small-scale qualitative research (Braun & Clarke, 2006, 2012). Thematic analysis was selected for its effectiveness in exploring participants' perceptions and identifying commonalities in their responses (Ryan & Bernard, 2003). This iterative process of synthesizing codes into themes could have continued indefinitely. This method ensures a balanced analysis, capturing both anticipated insights from established theoretical contexts and novel, unforeseen themes. It leverages the strengths of semi-structured interviews to provide a comprehensive understanding of the data.

4.5 Ethics

While conducting this empirical research with human participants, I will adhere to the guidelines provided by The British Educational Research Association (2018) to mitigate harm and safeguard the well-being of the participants. Before participation, participants are fully apprised of the study's aims, benefits, potential risks, their right to withdraw and data protection measures through the information sheet provided. The consent form ensures voluntariness, full disclosure, and willingness to include their experiences and insights in this study. During and after participation, stringent measures will be taken to protect the personal information of participants. The data collected will be treated as pseudonyms in the essay to protect participants' privacy and prevent any potential breaches of confidentiality. Data will be securely stored in a laptop with a password, accessible only to myself, and handled following data protection regulations, ensuring its use is confined strictly to the research. Maintaining

transparency during the research process ensures that participants and the public are informed about the study's outcomes.

5 Findings and Discussions

This study aims to identify the reasons for Chinese international students' better or less cultural fit-in. Specifically, it examines how pre-transition habitus and capital are associated with their post-transition fit-in choices. Empirical evidence indicates that students engage in local culture to varying extents. In general, the results of their cultural fit—whether to integrate or to withdraw—are associated with their pre-transition inherent capital and habitus. The research indicates students who further adapt and better fit-in tend to have better adaptability and are more capable of gathering valuable information.

5.1 Adaptive Habitus and Adaptability as a Habitus

Many Chinese international students had prepared extensively in pre-transition. They meet people who will also live in the UK beforehand or learn about their new environment. More indicative of the globally shared elite's mechanism is the adaptive habitus they developed since childhood and keep applicable after the transition. Almost all international undergraduates in this research had envisioned their educational paths to some extent since they were young and did international courses at least during their high school period. In

other words, they are prepared to "become international." Thus, they arrive in the UK with capitals and habitus applicable there.

On the other hand, those students without assistance at their fingertips had to be active in gathering and filtering information, reinforcing their habitus parallel to changing situations since the undergraduate application. Upon arrival, because studying in the UK was not mainstream in their original environments, they lacked the ready-made contacts or institutional knowledge that other students might possess. However, as the saying goes, teaching a man to fish is more beneficial than giving him a fish. Interviews with participants uncovered that, for some of them, their habitus is adaptable, while for others, adaptivity had become a part of their habitus through previous experience. The following sections distinguish the differences.

5.1.1 Behind the Choice of Adaption or Withdrawal

Overall, the study found that the achievement of cultural fit among international students largely depends on their choices when confronted with a sense of cultural dislocation. Many external factors, such as timely help, can influence this process. One interviewee, Stephanie, described it as "organically happening." The substantial empirical evidence shows that different reactions to cleft habitus, when international students' ingrained behaviours and thoughts no longer align with their settings, lead to different integration outcomes. Their reactions and actions closely relate to the habitus formed before studying abroad. As Newsome and Cooper (2016) highlighted, students' responses to cultural shock vary. Some develop a deeper self-awareness and appreciation for different cultures, while others may withdraw from exposure to conflicting beliefs and avoid interaction with the broader society.

International students often struggle to form meaningful interactions with local culture due to cultural and linguistic barriers, as shown by Scanlon, Rowling, and Weber (2007). Significant cultural differences intensify psychological tension and affective turmoil during social interactions, leading many students to retreat (Friedman, 2016; Ivemark and Ambrose, 2023), using shyness as an excuse (Sovic, 2009). At first, students who intend to integrate into the community may tentatively attribute their challenges to personal ignorance. Over time, they recognize the external barriers, such as existing social circles among domestic students, deter deeper integration. Two of the participants, Wenyi and Mengke, originally had the ambitions to meet local friends and integrate into a broader community:

Group work with local students taught me that overcoming cultural differences requires substantial effort. Considering my eventual return to China, full integration seems unnecessary. (Wenyi)

Similarly, Mengke claimed how her established "social bubble" dragged her into a comfort zone and ultimately gave up further attempts.

Describing the Chinese student community as closed and segregated is overly simplistic (Chen and Ross, 2015). Among my participants, there are individuals who actively assimilate into the UK environment, achieving better cultural fit. O'Shea (2019) describes these obstacles with the metaphor of "traversable boundaries," suggesting that while barriers imply rigid, insurmountable blocks, boundaries are traversable and potentially meant to be crossed (Tsui & Law, 2007). Some participants have used their "self-in-between mobility" (Wang, 2022) to seize opportunities to "learn about other people's thoughts" (Spencer-Oatey et al., 2017).

According to responses from participants, as "straddlers" of "epistemic privilege", they are recalibrating actions flexibly across different educational and social contexts (O'Shea, 2019). This habitus allows transnational communication and connections, underscoring the intrinsic value of maintaining multiple cultural affiliations (Lubrano, 2004; Kim, 2010). As Xiao said, although he "lives here in a Chinese way," he enjoys learning about different cultures from foreign friends. He is open to trying new things that are impressive and rewarding, such as consumption habits, including second-hand stores and Black Friday. Narratives from the interviews with better fit-in students affirm O'Shea (2019) of students' self-imposed need to be willing to re-negotiate their awareness and position during the transition. In the context of globalization, the habitus of being "organic, intrinsic, implicit, and reflexive" (Lehmann, 2013) valued by society is particularly rewarding for international students. Surprisingly, some participants demonstrated through their responses that as one dimension of "becoming international", this habitus have been developed before their transition through their pre-transition education.

5.1.2 Transfer with Adaptive Habitus

As articulated by Edgerton and Roberts (2014, p.199), habitus is "adaptive" and "incrementally modifiable in the face of variant circumstances". Swidler (1986) employs the metaphor of a "tool kit" to describe habitus and show how an individual's social position profoundly influences the cultural practices, habits, and skills used to address the challenges. Based on the findings of this study, this toolkit seems to have the potential to move with its owner and continue to be effective in new environments. In other words, its applicability in new settings depends on how relevant it remains when its owner is in the new settings. Following this, the relevance not only determines the toolkit's applicability but also mirrors

the relevance between two habitus occurring simultaneously, a phenomenon Bourdieu (2006, 2008) identifies as leading to the emergence of cleft habitus.

Students view the degree of adaptation to academic life as a fundamental aspect of their overall adaptation to the university experience. Obviously, their prior academic preparations have significantly aided their transition. The significance of studying independently and the awareness to adapt based on personal circumstances in university are well-recognized by participants, with many of them developing independent study habits and adaptability during high school. Yiwen reflected, "I'd say what I learnt in high school was probably self-study." Similarly, Haocheng noted, "...more resources are available through UCL's online platform," exactly fit the self-study habits he cultivated in high school.

Information collection and collation is a habitus that continues benefiting students. More than one participant mentioned using customizable comparative tables. They usually developed this skill during high school for university application. It is still helpful in module selections or internship applications now. Tracing back, Yutong attributes this habitus of systematically organizing information to an internship she undertook during her high school years. "That's when I learned how to utilize this Excel, even though I used to be overwhelmed by such data processing software before," she recounts. Broadly speaking, this underscores the educational value of integrating practical, real-world experiences into learning. It is a hallmark of elite education that constantly prepares students for academic and workplace challenges to maintain their socio-economic status.

Xiao and Mengke did not initially attend A-level schools; they managed through traditional public schools' intense, exam-focused environment. Experience in these top-tier public schools significantly endowed them with certain capabilities that have proven advantageous

in their UK studies. To illustrate, Xiao discussed how he learned the importance of mastering topics through extensive practice. Likewise, Mengke emphasized how handling both A-level and Gaokao exams simultaneously equipped her to manage multiple tasks calmly and efficiently in university. These pre-transition preparations are not merely an embodiment of the elite class's ability to afford costly international education but rather an expected outcome of elite education in a broad sense.

5.1.3 Adaptability as a Rewarding Habitus

Adaptative habitus indicates the existence of the elites' mechanism that rewards privileged communities in the global wide. However, relying solely on established habitus to adapt to new environments often proves insufficient. Challenges such as unforeseen cultural differences, unexpected cultural shocks, or a lack of sufficient capital and experience in the UK can lead to a cleft habitus, which limits opportunities (Lee and Kramer, 2012). In response, there are some students who engage in continual self-reflection, reevaluating their dispositions and transforming challenges into opportunities for better cultural and academic integration (Ivemark and Ambrose, 2023). This "internal 'tug' between contradictory schemes" is reminiscent of Ingram's (2018, p.954) observations of working-class students in elite education negotiating dual cultural expectations where "conflicting dispositions awkwardly intermingle."

The inherent adaptivity of habitus bestows a strong inertia, which sometimes makes it challenging for individuals to adapt to fields that deviate from their initial conditioning (Bourdieu & Wacquant, 2001). Overcoming this inertia demands open-mindedness to change and the emotional capacity to stomach the upheavals of the new settings.

In high school, people came to you. However, in university, you need to reach out continually. I don't want to limit my experiences, so I shift towards more engaged and autonomous approaches. (Yifan)

This rapid assimilation of new habitus or, in other words, modification of their habitus aligns with the new "rules of the game" in new settings, highlighting adaptability as an essential competence after the transition.

Haocheng points out the cognitive adaptation needed when confronting deeply ingrained cultural practices, such as deferring exams with illness—a practice often seen as a lack of perseverance in Chinese culture. Some students become aware of their cognitive limitations and incorporate beneficial habits or mindsets observed in the new environment, and importantly, they make changes based on this awareness. Yifan initially perceived the strategic utilization of rules as deceptive but soon recognized the importance of actively understanding and capitalizing on these available opportunities. Her internal struggles exemplify cleft habitus; her shift from passive compliance to proactive engagement exemplifies the evolution of her habitus to align more closely with the new demands.

Adaptability as habitus often comes from sensitive observation of circumstances, conjoined with constant reflection, and changes are made based on awareness. This habitus can also be backtracked to the experiences before coming to the UK. Yifan's school was an elite one renowned in China as a "cradle for cultivating foreign language diplomatic talents." With a strong emphasis on English proficiency and open-minded ethos, she described the school's educational approach as "enlightenment-oriented". Probably influenced by that, she reflected constantly on diverse topics, such as her social privileges and how to utilize them positively. Unlike most undergraduates, Haocheng, who had never participated in A-level examinations,

had a tumultuous educational journey. After attending one of Shanghai's top public high schools, he was enrolled on a premier university in China, but he took a gap year to set up his own business. Later, he dropped out and joined a foundation course at UCL. "I prepared nothing when I first came to the UK, but I believed I was prepared since I am very adaptable", confessed Haocheng. Immersed in a multicultural environment and more diverse formative experiences engage more in constant self-reflection as a more classified mechanism, assisting them to transcend traditional geographical boundaries and dynamically shape their identities (Marginson, 2014; Rizvi, 2011; Gill, 2010; Wang, 2020). Through persistent reflection and modification, they interact broadly with the host society and spontaneously establish intercultural contact, as described by Yu & Moskal(2018).

5.2 Consistent Access to Useful Information

Lareau and Horvat (1999) observed that the value of capital varies across different social settings, indicating that informational capital may dilute during transnational transitions. This section discusses the factors that influence international students' information gathering and application, focusing on four key dimensions: language, existing social networks, social skills, and the quality of information.

5.2.1 Language as the Foundation

One interesting observation is that although most undergraduates are not hindered seriously by their English proficiency, there remains a considerable gap between basic language skills and the ability to build and keep relationships and access exclusive information without

language barriers. Particularly for these undergraduates who study abroad, most of them have been intensely exposed to the English environment and international education. Mengke, for example, developed her English skills robustly in both public schools and A-level courses, boosting her confidence in communicating with peers and instructors. Although these students rarely suffer from severe language impairment, there are still challenges due to incomplete mastery, occasionally leading to troubles. For instance, Yiwen recalled, "I misunderstood the title of a business analysis module. I expected it to be data analysis in statistics, but it actually often involves writing analytical reports, which I hate."

Wenyi pointed out that language exam preparation is insufficient for addressing real-world problems. As she shared, "this helplessness was maximized when infected with flu. I was too sick to figure out how to see a doctor or what medicine to take." Likewise, even though informal conversations might be manageable for Yutong, she feels depressed by the stark disparity in language depth compared to native speakers. Differently, schooling in a predominantly native English-speaking environment seems to facilitate deeper integration for Stephanie. Her native-level English has significantly facilitated her deeper integration into the local environment and make native British friends. In that case, Stephanie not only "felt very comfortable going to them and asking personal stuff," but the insights provided by her British friends were generally unavailable to the Chinese student community. For example, unlike Wenyi, when Stephanie experiences a flare-up of her skin condition, she can apply the healthcare tips she had learned through casual conversations in daily interactions with the locals.

The multi-layered experience of Yifan further shows how differences in language skills influence adaptation. Initially lacking confidence in English, she hesitated to try new things.

Every year, returning to the UK after leaving the English environment for the summer feels like I'm estranged from English... I'd listen to podcasts to get back into it. After reacclimating to English, I'd start going out to watch plays, visit exhibitions, and participate in volunteering. (Yifan)

Hence, it could conceivably be suggested that, as a condition to get into the community, once language is not a limitation to explore, international students would utilize it as a tool to get more information.

5.2.2 Existing Social Network as the First-aid Station

For some Chinese undergraduates in this study, their social networks shift with their transition, while others rely on proactively developing new connections and gaining access to rich and reliable information. If informational capital is considered the "rules of the game," then pre-college experiences involve forming specific preliminary alliances and cooperation with fellow players before the game starts. Terenzini et al. (1994, p.65) view pre-college friends as a transitional bridge during the initial weeks or months of college, connecting one academic and interpersonal environment to another. As students' social networks expand and they forge closer relationships with new acquaintances, the significance of high school friendships gradually wanes (Terenzini et al., 1994). However, the findings of this study suggest that for Chinese international students, these pre-college friends continue to provide solid support and crucial information amidst life's uncertainties (Ramsay, Jones & Barker, 2006). Within the first three months of arriving in London, Yiwen felt anxious and insecure, during which time she found hanging out with her high school friends sufficiently met her social needs. Echoed with Yutong's experience that even though she now spends more time with coursemates, high school friends remain her most supportive network.

Due to these students' preparations for becoming international before going abroad, which included getting to know peers with similar future pathways, the endurance of pre-college social networks is ensured. The A-level requirements of universities force students and their families to prepare and make decisions in advance. Xiao, for example, transferred from a public school to an A-level school, where he was one of 600 graduates that year. Enrolling in this school means giving up higher education in China and aiming for a UK university. These shared educational paths facilitate connections with peers who have similar academic plans. Alongside him, 79 of his peers, including seven pursuing the same major, came to UCL the same year. Before university, Xiao and his classmates, who also enrolled at UCL, reviewed numerous websites to familiarize themselves with university policies. This preparation helps bridge potential information gaps among them. Since these networks were formed with the expectation of following similar developmental paths, their networks naturally retain as they continue to live in the same environment and support each other through daily challenges. These continuously applicable networks in an overseas environment "improve coping capacities and minimize the risk of misinformation and miscommunication" (Tasic & Amir, 2016, p. 4).

Social networks serve as primary sources of information about academic requirements and university life and play a vital role in moderating the transition. For example, London's high living costs normally unsettle international students (Brown & Holloway, 2008). However, forewarnings from a high school upperclassman who had arrived in the UK earlier helped Wenyi prepare mentally:

Of course, it is still expensive, but the tip prepared me mentally. I lowered expectations about London in advance and was even ready for possible accidents. (Wenyi)

Insights from seniors in the high school community equipped not only international students in daily life but also provided real-life experience of study in UK universities, preventing academic frustration.

Before my application, he (an upperclassman) described the academic stress of my program as almost 1.5 times that of others. Being aware of the high-intensity nature of it meant a calmer acceptance of limited opportunities for activities. (Xiao)

Beyond individual social networks, the family continues to exert an evident influence, just as Xiao still relies on his parents' resources when seeking internship and research opportunities. Comparably, Yutong's parents use their social networks to assist her in gathering information and making informed decisions. It illustrates that although social networks built after transition might somewhat replace family (Cassidy, 2004), informational capital provided by family of origin remains irreplaceable (Oyefuga and Shakeshaft, 2021).

Moreover, as the participants said, the pattern of seeking information, such as consulting with upperclassmen, largely persists upon arrival in the UK. Younger students valued the seasoned perspectives of their seniors. In particular, some participants noted that transition mentors assigned by the school provided considerable help in comprehending their new environment. As mentioned in the literature review, belonging to the international student community and sharing special bonds with people from the same background provide them considerable support. In various national and institutional contexts, the Chinese Students and Scholars Association (CSSA) plays a similar role as "peer-mentoring and the sharing of academic

information" (Chen and Ross, 2015, p.165). As a CSSA member, Yifan has formed many friends there. On the other hand, for Wenyi, CSSA's social media account provides a lot of reliable information. These responses confirm Chen and Ross's (2015) finding that the social frameworks established by pioneers with similar backgrounds, such as existing societies and clubs, have either enhanced or sustained the social status of Chinese students abroad.

5.2.3 Social Skills as the Supply Depot

In the absence of pre-existing social networks, some students manage to forge new connections through their social skills. With these skills, some of them achieve even better cultural integration. Graduates from Yifan's high school typically pursue their university studies in China or the US. To everyone's surprise, she settled for an off-the-wall option—that of the UK—whose situation knew almost nobody before arrival. Despite that, her active involvement in various societies and constant interaction with new people since high school made her adaptation to this new environment more manageable. "I've met and built relationships one by one here," she said, expressing high satisfaction with her success in building a supportive network since arrival.

Furthermore, Yifan said that running a choir she founded herself boosts her confidence. With the choir's success, Yifan felt determined to do whatever she wanted—working part-time in a restaurant, volunteering in school, and private tutoring. All these tryouts significantly enriched her experiences and formed a positive cycle.

While participants realized that geographical relocations might weaken social networks, and existing relationships might hinder deeper cultural integration—making individuals "reluctant

to step out and make new friends," as Mengke pointed out—social skills cultivated in one's original setting do not become obsolete when changing environments. Instead, they act as reliable and immediately applicable assets in new contexts. Empirical evidence illustrates that social networks result from and constitute readily available capital, whereas social skills are a form of yielding habitus, fostering adaptability. "There were ten people in the group, but only I met him in the end. He ranked the hardest courses each year for me. He told me how projects should be done as well," mentioned Xiao, indicating the formation of social relationships is significantly influenced by chance and initiative. Activeness as a social habit provides individuals with deeper connections and more extensive information.

In addition, for international students, not being confined by their customary social habits is beneficial. Lessky, Nairz-Wirth, and Feldmann (2021) noted that educational settings like seminars or group assignments offer substantial opportunities for forming friendships. According to participants, many international students find these academic settings ideals for forming connections as they continue the social practices they used to engage in during high school. Yifan, for example, met her closest friends while discussing gender issues during a group assignment in a feminism module. "We share gender-related discussions in our group chat now. I feel very comfortable to chat about these sensitive issues with them," she shared. Mengke echoed a similar sentiment:

I met people mainly through interactions in the classroom and within my major. It is a social science; we have many opportunities to share our thoughts in class. This communication helps us get to know our classmates better. And it provides the chance to hang out with people who match with you. (Mengke)

Interestingly, the situation varies significantly across disciplines. In contrast to Mengke's major in social science, Yiwen, studying Mathematics and Statistics, characterizes her major as highly competitive, where everyone operates independently. The exam ranking system and job-oriented nature contribute to this individualistic environment.

It's mainly about relying on oneself, which feels more trustworthy. What classmates say also needs time to check, sometimes not meeting expectations, so it's better to depend on oneself. (Yiwen)

This difference is consistent with Lessky, Nairz-Wirth, and Feldmann's (2021) observation that depending on the circumstances, some students may find it more challenging to foster mutual support and sustain relationships, relying instead on working on their own.

Few students from the schools attended by Stephanie and Haocheng pursued higher education in the UK. Their background was such that both of them rarely encountered peers applying to UK universities. Stephanie, raised in Shanghai at an international school exclusively for foreign nationals and operated by the US Embassy, found herself in a more globally oriented and informationally-rich environment than typical A-level course schools. However, "most people preferred going to or returning to the U.S. where they felt more comfortable," the school's consultants provided limited insights into UK universities and lacked robust alumni networks. With this situation, Stephanie took the initiative; after reading an interview with a girl from another international school on a social media platform who had applied to a UK law program, she reached out to arrange a coffee meeting. This interaction significantly influenced her choices in applying for undergraduate programs.

At the beginning of his first school term, Haocheng used his coding skills to access learning resources. Sharing precious resources with classmates to build initial connections is one

strategy he took to expand his social network. Unsatisfied with his first dorm, where most residents were Chinese, and everyone was too content in their comfort zones, merely engrossed in card games, he moved into an international dorm. There, he immersed himself in a mix of cultures, a strategic move aimed at broadening his social interactions and seizing new opportunities. Additionally, Haocheng's initiative also brought academic gains. For example, he bravely travelled to Cambridge with comprehensive materials to persuade a professor to admit him into a desired research group. Both Stephanie and Haocheng demonstrated proactivity, a critical social skill, which enabled them to expand their networks and gather helpful information after transitioning. Notably, they both exhibited the courage to step out of their comfort zones. Their confidence and initiative, quintessential traits fostered by elite education (Meiklejohn, Hickey, and Riddle, 2023), are the reasons they continually seize opportunities, striving for success that, in turn, leads to even more cultural fit opportunities.

5.2.4 Quality of the Information as the Watershed

The effectiveness of information is primarily determined by its relevance to individuals, not merely by its abundance. Aligning with the previously discussed concept of information capital, the value of information lies in its applicability and potential conversion into beneficial capital rather than its sheer volume. A key strategy that enables individuals to utilize rules effectively, rather than being constrained by them, is the careful selection and discerning filtration of information. Haocheng noted the importance of maintaining a "dynamic balance" with information and rules: "It's not about rigidly adhering to the rules nor expending all efforts on exploiting the hidden rules." Similarly, Yifan pointed out her selective engagement with available resources:

I don't make much use of the career centre because I prioritize my campus life. This decision is a trade-off, saving me time for what I value more. (Yifan)

By determining whether the information is usable for oneself, these students strategically select, integrate, and apply it to their educational pathways, internships, and other achievements. Informational capital thus represents the "rules of the game," necessitating that players not only know the game but also understand the correct strategies for engagement.

When students face challenges accessing information, they often turn to external aids, with hiring consultants as a straightforward solution. Yutong remarks, "Almost everyone uses off-campus consultants." For these students, the cost of consulting fees is secondary to the ease of obtaining information. However, this immediate approach can lead to overlooked information reliability and appropriateness evaluations. Wenyi highlighted a more significant concern, "I consulted an external advisor who thought I'd suit Education Studies, but she didn't know me, nor did I know Education Studies." Moreover, as Mengke described, some consultants, despite their supposed expertise in overseas education, have no experience with studying abroad. Hence, they can't provide targeted advice.

Therefore, more important than easily accessible information is the ability to judiciously evaluate it. Students should prioritize directness and reliability, such as seeking firsthand information from official sources. These capabilities and judgments are rooted in strategically using capital and adapting tactics to unfamiliar academic fields. This awareness, described by Sullivan et al. (2016) as a vital skill for maintaining one's position in higher social echelons, can fall under the globally recognized and rewarded mechanisms identified by Winkler and Sriram (2015).

From high school, Haocheng recognised the value of firsthand information in navigating unfamiliar environments. Due to internet regulations in China, he learned to use a Virtual Private Network to access Western universities' official websites years ago when applying for a summer camp. He was the sole participant who did not hire off-campus consultants in application. This manner of acquiring information while simultaneously being judgmental allowed him to "apply to undergraduate programs with minimal detours." This practice has evolved, enabling him to excel through information advantages over other students. In university, the occasion to make informed decisions based on the reliability and relevance of information became more common. Just as Stephanie prefers to gather insights from senior students about course details not listed on official sites: "This information is hard to seek but is crucial."

Stephanie's keenness for information was shaped by her regrettable decision three years ago. Born in Hong Kong—a former British colony—she believed that studying in the UK would better align with her career prospects, particularly because of the similarities in the judicial systems. Reflecting on her choice of study location, she admits, "But that was not the case." She now regrets basing her decision solely on imagination and a consultant's advice without adequate career planning or seeking opinions from experienced law practitioners. This mentality she shares underscores the importance of informational capital in understanding the hidden mechanisms of the system, as highlighted by Santos and Costa (2015), who give the example of how hierarchies differentiate degrees in terms of academic quality, social prestige, and value.

Unlike some students equipped with ready-to-use resources and skills, Stephanie's education emphasized empowering students to dynamically adapt and develop their capabilities to secure resources. Engaging in numerous trials when the cost of error was relatively low

provided her with experiences and insights that later heightened her sensitivity to information. Now, she employs more varied methods to gather and verify information, explaining, "Through internships and discussions with legal professionals at different stages, I realized..." Likewise, Haocheng's independence from his parents' intervention, supported by ample resources, allowed him to embark on ventures like starting a business in Africa during a gap year. It was during this period that he truly understood the meaning of the information gap and learned to exploit it for gains. They eventually accessed exclusive information through the habitus they honed. However, the habitus they used to grasp these opportunities was shaped by accumulated experience in elite education. As Gavillet (2019) notes, the benefits of elite education often stem from the accumulation of resources and enriching experiences that provide guidance and fault tolerance for their future choices (Nespor, 2014).

6 Conclusion

In conclusion, the primary finding is that the ability of international students to adapt to life abroad and continuously gather valuable information is often developed through a globally esteemed elite mechanism before their transition. If informational capital represents the "rules of the game," the occurrence of cleft habitus presents each player with a choice. Consistent with existing research, cultural shock may be pervasive for international students, which usually thrust individuals into crisis. Successful cultural fit depends on whether this instance is perceived as an opportunity to achieve better fit-in rather than a signal to retreat and withdraw. Depending on their available resources and experience, individuals make different choices. Some Chinese international students use their accumulated pre-existing habitus, information, and social networks to cushion the initial discomforts of arriving in a new environment. This strategy helps minimize internal struggles and facilitates a smoother transition to university life overseas. However, to transcend superficial integration and gain a richer experience, well-developed social networking skills, command of crucial information, and proactivity in seizing opportunities should be necessary. Some Chinese international students may actively integrate into the new environment under the guidance of their pre-existing habitus, achieving a better cultural fit that involves more significant interaction with

the local culture. Continuously accessing efficient information about the new environment using various strategies is decisive in this process.

Current research on international students primarily emphasizes the post-study-abroad advantages and subsequent transformation in students' lives as they manage to shift socio-cultural contexts to develop transnational identities and cultivate diverse selves. Instead of discussing the benefits of study abroad experiences, this study shifts attention to the existing capitals and habitus that shape international students' experiences in foreign academic and social environments. Specifically, the focus seeks to understand how the privileges of international students before studying abroad shape the practice forms that achieve cultural fit in their overseas experiences. In doing this, it complements existing research by filling a gap in understanding the antecedents of successful cultural fit. The findings also enhance the scope of employing Bourdieu's framework in discussing straddlers' situation in facing navigational difficulties within unfamiliar cultural territories. By offering critical insights into the transition challenges of international students, these considerations are necessary in developing a more inclusive and supportive educational environment to address their variegated needs.

The study also acknowledges limitations. Although the qualitative approach provides depth, through the small sample size of eight participants from a controlled background, it lacks the breadth and statistical power for broader generalizations. Relying solely on Bourdieu's framework may restrict the interpretation of empirical results to one perspective. The sample of eight Chinese international students from a single university does not represent all Chinese students across the UK. Moreover, China's cultural and economic diversity suggests that students from different backgrounds might encounter unique challenges. This research captures a specific period of students' experiences. Future studies could employ longitudinal methods to watch changes over time, adding insights into the dynamics of cultural fit. Besides,

integrating quantitative and qualitative methodologies in future research could enhance the validity and breadth of understanding regarding the issues at hand.

7 Reference List

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8 Appendix

Appendix 1

BA Education Studies Dissertation Ethics Application Form 2023-2024

Once you have gained the approval of your supervisor, you must upload the signed form in the 'BA dissertation ethics application form' submission box (available within the Ethics tab on moodle) at least one week before you plan to commence data collection.

Name: GWLS2

Title: Mapping the Journey: Understanding the Role of Habitus and Capitals in Chinese International Students' Cultural Fit

Confirmation of Informed Consent. Will you gain the informed consent of participants? How will this be obtained?

Yes, participants will be contacted via my ucl email address for confirmation of their willingness and pre-interview questions to gather essential information. The informed consent will be provided before the interview. Prior to their participation, participants will be fully informed about the research's objectives, benefits, potential risks, and data protection measures. This information will be provided through participant information sheets and written informed consent forms, which will be designed to ensure competence, non-coercion, full disclosure, and comprehension. Participants will be given the opportunity to understand and agree to take part in the research, including being made aware of any potential harm. They will also have the right to withdraw their participation at any point during the study.

Will you guarantee the anonymity and confidentiality of your participants? How will this be achieved?

Yes, I am committed to ensuring the anonymity and confidentiality of participants throughout the research process. I would claim that if the interview is taken place in any public space, then there might be a decrease in confidentiality. There may also limits to confidentiality if they tell you something that may put themselves, you or other people in danger. This will be explicitly communicated to participants in the information sheet. However, confidentiality will be rigorously upheld by employing aliases and obscuring specific personal details, including but not limited to exact location, institution, or occupation, as necessary. To achieve this, all personal identifiers will be carefully removed and replaced with pseudonyms to keep authenticity and respect for participants. The results will be presented in aggregate form, ensuring that individual participants cannot be identified. Additionally, all data will be securely stored, and access will be restricted to authorized members of the research team to safeguard participant information.

Storage of Data.

During the Research:

Where will the data be stored? What measures will you take to ensure the safe storage of data.

All personal data will be stored and processed in compliance with the General Data Protection Registration (GDPR). Data collected will be processed anonymously in research findings to safeguard participants' privacy and prevent any potential breaches. The recordings will be transcribed as fast as possible after the interview and deleted immediately.

Transcribed documents are uploaded to UCL (N:) Drive which provides secure, encrypted file storage that is backed up daily. All transcribed and analytical documents are deleted at the end of the academic year. Compliance with data protection regulations will be maintained, and data will not be used for any purposes beyond the research.

After the Research:

Where will the data be stored?

How long will the data and records be kept for and in what format?

I will delete all the data after I received my BA qualification. And I will not be archiving my data for other researchers to use.

Confirm that all personal data will be stored and processed in compliance with the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR). (see guidance on moodle).

Yes ☒

Are there particular features of the proposed work which may raise ethical concerns or add to the complexity of ethical decision making? If so, please outline how you will deal with these.

It is important that you demonstrate your awareness of potential risks or harm that may arise as a result of your research. You should then demonstrate that you have considered ways to minimise the likelihood and impact of each potential harm that you have identified. Please be as specific as possible in describing the ethical issues you will have to address. Please consider / address ALL issues that may apply.

Ethical concerns may include, but not be limited to, the following areas:

- | | |
|--|--|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none">- Methods- Sampling- Recruitment- Gatekeepers- Informed consent- Potentially vulnerable participants- Safeguarding/child protection- Sensitive topics | <ul style="list-style-type: none">- International research- Risks to participants and/or researchers- Confidentiality/Anonymity- Disclosures/limits to confidentiality- Data storage and security both during and after the research (including transfer, sharing, encryption, protection)- Reporting- Dissemination and use of findings |
|--|--|

My research covers the sensitive and personal topics of people's social economic status. It is important to maintain a fair and balanced representation of fair and unbiased treatment of all participants, irrespective of their gender, age, university, proficiency and personal experiences will be ensured. Throughout the project I will ensure that I reflect on my position to minimize bias. Participants will confirm their voluntariness through my UCL email address and will ensure that the participant information form and written informed consent are signed by them prior to the start of the interview. I will use anonymity methods such as pseudonyms to ensure the confidentiality of this study. Audio recordings will be transcribed as soon as possible and deleted immediately. The transcription files will be stored in a password protected UCL (N:) and no one other than myself and my supervisor will have access to it. All participants will be able to withdraw at any time until the 1st of April. Transparency throughout the research process will allow participants and the public to be informed about the research methodology and results. Additionally, external oversight and peer review will be welcomed to guarantee the scientific validity and reliability of the research methods.

Please attach the consent form and information sheet templates along with this form if you are undertaking empirical research. This is a prerequisite to gaining ethical approval for your project.

I have read, understood and will abide by the BERA set of guidelines (if you are adhering to a different set of guidelines- eg. British Sociological Association, state here).

Yes: ☒

No: ☐

I confirm that to the best of my knowledge:

The above information is correct and that this is a full description of the ethics issues that may arise in the course of this project.

Student's signature:

GWLS2

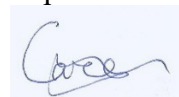
27/01/2024

Final Approval by Supervisor. It should be noted that the initial submission of this form (as an appendix to the final draft of your research proposal) is likely to lead to suggested amendments by your supervisor (e.g. requests for clarification, suggestions for considerations of ethical issues that may have been overlooked etc.). Once all relevant considerations have been sufficiently addressed your supervisor will sign below.

Supervisor's Approval

I am satisfied the relevant ethical considerations have been addressed:

Supervisors Signature



Date: 25/01/2024

Any Further comments:

Once the above approval by the supervisor has been granted, the signed form must be uploaded by the student on the Ethics Approval Submission box **at least one week before**

you plan to begin data collection:

<https://moodle.ucl.ac.uk/course/view.php?id=34946§ion=22>

Appendix 2

Mapping the Journey: Understanding the Role of Habitus and Capitals in Chinese International Students' Cultural Fit

11/2023-5/2024

Information sheet for interviewees

My name is GWLS2 and I am inviting you to take in part in my research project, Mapping the Journey: Understanding the Role of Habitus and Capitals in Chinese International Students' Cultural Fit. I am an undergraduate student at the UCL Institute of Education currently working on my dissertation research. The Institute of Education is responsible for a quarter of all education research in the UK and has consistently held the top global ranking in the field of Education for eight consecutive years (UCL 2021).

In this study I am hoping to delve into the impact of mobility on international students' habitus, examining their level of awareness and how this phenomenon influences their lived experiences. This research aims to explore the experiences of international students during global transitions. I very much hope that you would like to take part. This information sheet will try and answer any questions you might have about the project, but please don't hesitate to contact me if there is anything else you would like to know.

Who is carrying out the research?

All research is carried out by GWLS2 with support from my supervisor Olga Cara.

Why are we doing this research?

I would like to learn about your study abroad experience compared to your previous experiences in the home country and what the study abroad experience offered you.

Why am I being invited to take part?

You are selected because you are currently studying abroad, and you are an undergraduate student that meets the requirements of this study.

What will happen if I choose to take part?

You are expected to participate in a 30-minute in person interview to discuss your personal experience and insights. I will begin with some simple personal questions as an icebreaker and then invite you to share your study abroad experiences and discuss your views and attitudes. All questions are open and there no right or wrong answers.

Will anyone know I have been involved?

Although this is a face-to-face interview, I will still ensure maximum anonymity and confidentiality. The recordings will be stored under the labels of your pseudonym. All transcripts and following analysis in the dissertation will not contain your names or any other identifiable information. Besides, you always have the right to withdrawal. Please inform me by 1st April.

Could there be problems for me if I take part?

You will not be judged by your performance during the research and there will be no consequences regarding if you decide not to answer some or all questions during the interview. All the results will be presented anonymously.

What will happen to the results of the research?

I will be recording this interview, but all recordings will be stored anonymously on a password-protected drive and will be deleted after transcripts have been made. No other use will be made of the data without your written permission, and no one outside the project will be allowed access to the original recordings.

Do I have to take part?

It is entirely up to you whether or not you choose to take part. I hope that if you do choose to be involved then you will find it a valuable experience. If you choose to participate, you will receive this information sheet for your records and will be requested to sign a consent form. You have the option to withdraw at any point, and your decision will not impact any entitled benefits. In the event of withdrawal, you will be inquired about your preferences regarding the data you have contributed up to that point. The decision is not related to any grades.

Data Protection Privacy Notice

The data controller for this project will be University College London (UCL). The UCL Data Protection Office provides oversight of UCL activities involving the processing of personal data, and can be contacted at data-protection@ucl.ac.uk. UCL's Data Protection Officer can also be contacted at data-protection@ucl.ac.uk. Further information on how UCL uses participant information can be found here:

<https://www.ucl.ac.uk/legal-services/privacy/ucl-general-research-participant-privacynotice>

The legal basis that would be used to process your *personal data* will be UK GDPR legislation. The legal basis used to process *special category personal data* will be for scientific and historical research or statistical purposes/explicit consent.

Your personal data will be processed so long as it is required for the research project.

If we are able to anonymise or pseudonymise the personal data you provide we will undertake this, and will endeavour to minimise the processing of personal data wherever possible. If you are concerned about how your personal data is being processed, or if you would like to contact us about your rights, please contact UCL in the first instance at data-protection@ucl.ac.uk.

Contact for further information

If you have any further questions before you decide whether to take part, you can reach me at email: stnvyg9@ucl.ac.uk, mobile: 07493830444.

If you would like to be involved, please complete the following consent form and return to stnvyg9@ucl.ac.uk.

Thank you very much for taking the time to read this information sheet.

Appendix 3

Mapping the Journey: Understanding the Role of Habitus and Capitals in Chinese International Students' Cultural Fit Consent for Interviews: Chinese International Students

(tick as appropriate)

I confirm that I have read and understood the information sheet, and have had the opportunity to consider the information, ask questions, and have had these questions adequately answered. ☐

I understand that my participation is voluntary and that I am free to withdraw at any time, without giving any reason. ☐

I know that I can refuse to answer any or all of the questions and that I can withdraw from the interview at any point. ☐

I agree for the interview to be recorded, and that recordings will be kept secure and destroyed at the end of the project. I know that all data will be kept under the terms of the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR). ☐

I agree that small direct quotes may be used in reports (these will be anonymised). ☐

In understand that in exceptional circumstances anonymity and confidentiality would have to be broken, for example, if it was felt that my wellbeing is at risk, or there were concerns regarding academic misconduct or any safeguarding issues. In these circumstances advice would be sought from my dissertation supervisor and the module leader who will advise as to the appropriate course of action and as to whether an authority needs to be informed. ☐

Name:.....

Signature: Date:

Name of researcher: GWLS2

Signature: GWLS2 Date:27/01/2024

Appendix 4

Interview Guide

Warm-up: context pre-departure in China

- 1 Which subject are you majoring in UCL? How does it compare so far to what you expected when you chose this school and your major?
 - Is there useful suggestion you gained during the application.
- 2 Could you tell me a little about your educational background? Which high school did you attend in China, and how would you describe the education this school provided?
 - Was your high school an international school and have you studied the British curriculum? How has this school experience impacted your studies uni in the UK?
- 3 Have your nuclear family members ever experience higher education? Have they described their experiences with you?
 - How do this information compare to your actual experiences at UCL?
 - How has this knowledge affected your expectations and adaptation to life in the UK?
- 4 What actions did you take to prepare and adapt more effectively? (For example, did you watch educational videos, learn specific dialects, or study colloquial expressions to blend in?)
 - How useful do you think is the information and skills you brought from China for studying in the UK?
 - Why did you feel it was necessary to take these actions?

Cultural Fit: Cultural Shock and Adaptation

- 1 Upon arriving in the UK, what aspects of both your daily life and academic settings did you find different compared to China? What and why do they seem different?
 - In what ways the academic practices in the UK are different from the ones in China? (e.g. treating higher education as a consumption, plagiarism and referencing policies and the use of AI?)
 - In what ways do you feel that language has played a role in your cultural adaptation process in academic environment? Can you share a particular incident where language either facilitated or hindered your cultural integration?
- 2 What strategies have you employed to adjust to the academic and social environment at UCL?
 - Have there been any specific cultural aspects that you've embraced or particularly struggled with?

- Reflecting on your journey since arriving in the UK, would you say you've experienced a series of stages starting with cultural shock, then moving to acceptance, and finally integrating new cultural experiences with your existing culture?
- Have there been moments during your time here when you've felt the need to withdraw or protect yourself from the cultural and psychological challenges of adapting?

Informational Capital

- 1 Can you give an example of a 'rule of the game' for studying in UCL?
- 2 Have you observed instances where your peers seemed to understand and utilize resources and policies more efficiently? E.g. Google Scholar, the Extenuating Circumstances, or the UCL Career Center
 - Are these students sharing any properties? (BBC/ABC? Local?)
 - What do you know about your dissertation or any exam and project you must pass in order to graduate (before year 3)?
- 3 How did you learn about critical timelines, such as exam schedules or assignment deadlines, and how important is this knowledge for your academic planning?
- 4 Have you experienced any setbacks due to unfamiliarity with these 'rules of the game' in the UK university system?
- 5 Through what channels have you found information that has been essential for navigating university life?
 - How did you come across these resources?
 - What role have platforms like WeChat groups, Whatsapp groups, or CSSA official accounts played in your social integration and information gathering?

Peer Network and Activities

- 1 Did you know any friends or seniors before coming here who already studied in the UK?
 - Have they shared their experiences with you? How has this network affected your adaptation to life in the UK?
 - What tips have you learned about navigating university life that were shared by current classmates or seniors when you arrived at the UK?

- 2 Have official school activities, such as the transition mentor program or orientation seminars, provided you with practical tips for university life?
 - Have university-organized social events been effective in helping you build lasting relationships? Can you give examples of such events and how they help you to gain more information?
- 3 Have you felt the difference in social interaction modes between university and high school?
 - What are they and how do you feel about them?
- 4 How well do you feel integrated into your peer group and the broader university community so far?
 - Does a sense of belonging or recognition contribute to you adapting more quickly?

Cleft Habitus

- 1 Is there any tensions between the cultural habits of your upbringing and the environment and your life in the UK?
 - Have there been specific situations where you've had to make a choice between following the cultural practices of your home country and those you've encountered in the UK? Could you describe that experience and the decision you made?
(Learn something you know won't be on a test or final paper or push yourself to attend the office hour)
- 2 Did you have to adapt to a new way of learning or a different academic expectation at UCL? Could you please mention some examples?
- 3 How have your pre-university habits and practices either facilitated or hindered your adaptation to the dominant academic and social norms at your university?
- 4 When you realize that you can't be culturally fit, do you think it's because you didn't try hard enough to reach out to these cultures, your family didn't provide a platform or because the school didn't assist you in a better way.